> As saints, we normally refrain ourselves from writing in the public domain on issues of policy and current discourse, but the way the discourse has been systematically vitiated in the last few weeks has compelled me to write this. The way the Kumbha Mela has been maligned has deeply pained not just me but crores of ordinary Hindus. Our most revered traditions have become part of a political tug-of-war, and that too, as part of some pre-planned tool-kit? What crime have the saints, seers and crores of ordinary Hindus committed that they have to be so shamed and humiliated in their own country?

He went on to say, 'First, the Kumbha mela is a millennia old tradition and the decision on time and date is taken by saints and seers based on astrological predictions.'[12]

Now, can you imagine restricting ascetics who only venture out of their caves, where they meditate for years on end, from performing what they consider the supreme act of cleansing for their soul? What kind of counter-reaction would it have generated? Would they have stayed put or would they have barged through police barricades despite the ban on the event and dipped into the holy waters? In such a situation, how would the police personnel have stopped the raging ascetics? Would the situation have gone out of hand? These were difficult but pertinent questions which the Uttarakhand government possibly had to consider when the decision on allowing a smaller, restricted Kumbha Mela was made. To their credit, they did manage to keep the attendance of devotees significantly limited over the three most important days of the festival as compared to previous years, as evidenced by key mobility indictors such as occupancy figures for all hotels in the district, vacancies in registered parking lots, cell phone presence accessed from mobile towers and passenger traffic from all vehicles and trains to and from Haridwar. For instance, on 14 April this year, the day of the Shahi Snan, only 12 lakh devotees took the holy dip as compared to 1.8 crore in the previous Shahi Shan in 2010. Local governments have a tendency to often exaggerate numbers, perhaps to demonstrate that they are capable of handling large footfalls. That seems to be precisely what happened in this case too. They initially claimed attendance numbers which they had to retract by calculating actual attendance figures after the High Court came down heavily on them. Inflated numbers presented by the local administration in conjunction with the skilfully shot visuals by crafty media